CULTURE SPOTLIGHT

You've Eaten It. Now Meet Where It Came From.

Food is the most direct path into a culture. Before language, before history, before art — there is a meal. Every dish carries memory, migration, and meaning. This is the story of what Pittsburgh is eating, and where it really came from.

Image credit: [https://amazingdumplings.com/gallery/14.jpg]

01 · Dumplings

Dumplings: A Northern Chinese Staple

Jiaozi traces back over 1,800 years to Eastern Han Dynasty physician Zhang Zhongjing, who cooked the first dumplings to help his patients keep warm and free from frostbite. Nowadays, they are a Chinese New Year special, with families folding them together being a long-held tradition.

As people migrated, dumplings traveled with them — becoming momo in Nepal, mandu in Korea, manti in Turkey, and even pierogi in Poland. Every culture that encountered it made it their own.

Amazing Dumplings in Squirrel Hill continues that tradition of reinvention — their colorful wrappers, tinted with natural ingredients, are a centuries-old shape still finding new expression.

Image credit: [Chengdu Gourmet, Pittsburgh]

02 · Mapo Tofu

Mapo Tofu: Mala Fire from Sichuan

Named after the famous inventor of the dish, "The Pockmarked (má) Old Madam (pó)", Mapo tofu is proof that the best recipes come from the most unexpected places — a small roadside eatery in 1860s Chengdu. The key to its success is the mala, a numbing spiciness unique to Sichuan cuisine, achieved through the combination of Sichuan peppercorns and chili. The peppercorn numbs, the chili burns, and together they create a sensation that has no Western parallel and no real substitute.

The dish has become a staple in Chinese cuisines, with Squirrel Hill's Chengdu Gourmet and Yuebaiwei serving the most authentic renditions Pittsburgh has to offer — a good reason to venture beyond the takeout menu.

Image credit: [Red Dragon, Pittsburgh]

03 · THE DIASPORA

General Tso’s Chicken and the Chinese-American Kitchen

General Tso's Chicken has no connection to its namesake, 19th Century Hunanese General Zuo Zongtang (Zuo is romanticized as Tso). The dish was invented by a Hunanese refugee chef in Taiwan, recreating the flavors of a homeland he could no longer return to.

When it arrived in New York, it was sweetened, softened, and made palatable to American tastes — and became one of the most ordered dishes in the country. That willingness to adapt without disappearing entirely is the defining story of Chinese-American cuisine. You change enough to be understood. You keep enough to stay yourself.

In Pittsburgh, Szechuan Express and How Lee carry that same legacy — feeding this city for generations.

Photo: Pittsburgh Chinese Cultural Center, Chinese Cultural Festival 2024

04 · The Festival Table

Skewers at the Cultural Festival

Every dish in this essay has shown up at the Pittsburgh Chinese Cultural Festival. Not in a museum. Not in a textbook. On a table, under a tent, in Schenley Park — shared between neighbors who may not share a language.

The festival, hosted annually by the Pittsburgh Chinese Cultural Center, brings together vendors, performers, and community members from across the region.

Among them is PF BBQ, specializing in skewers — a street food tradition deeply rooted in Chinese night market culture, drawing some of the longest lines of the day. This is what cultural preservation actually looks like. Not archived. Alive.

Image credit: [Novo Food Hall]

05 · CALL TO ACTION

Come to the Table

From the dumpling folds at Amazing Dumplings to the mala heat at Chengdu Gourmet, from the adapted classics at Szechuan Express and How Lee to the skewers at PF BBQ — Pittsburgh's Chinese food scene is deeper, older, and more alive than most people realize.

The Pittsburgh Chinese Cultural Center is the community behind all of it — hosting the Chinese Cultural Festival, the Lunar New Year Gala, and year-round cultural events that keep these traditions visible, shared, and celebrated.

Come to the table.

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